

# Coping frameworks for OCD/health anxiety patients during medical waiting periods — Action Checklist

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## RECOGNIZE YOUR SPIRAL PATTERN

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- ☐ **Notice your body's unique spiral signature by paying attention to physical warning signs like elevated heart rate, chest tightness, tingling in your extremities, or the sudden urge to check something, because spirals begin as nervous system events in your body before they become thoughts in your head.:** Notice your body's unique spiral signature by paying attention to physical warning signs like elevated heart rate, chest tightness, tingling in your extremities, or the sudden urge to check something, because spirals begin as nervous system events in your body before they become thoughts in your head.
- ☐ **Track the specific sequence of your spiral to identify whether it begins with a physical sensation, a specific thought, or an external trigger, so you can recognize and interrupt it earlier each time it occurs.:** Track the specific sequence of your spiral to identify whether it begins with a physical sensation, a specific thought, or an external trigger, so you can recognize and interrupt it earlier each time it occurs.
- ☐ **Watch for the narrowing attention pattern where all you can think about is the medical threat while everything else in your life fades from your awareness, because this attentional shift signals that a spiral is actively taking hold.:** Watch for the narrowing attention pattern where all you can think about is the medical threat while everything else in your life fades from your awareness, because this attentional shift signals that a spiral is actively taking hold.
- ☐ **Identify your specific compulsion urges such as the desire to check symptoms again, search online for answers, or call someone for reassurance, since naming these urges helps you resist performing them when they arise.:** Identify your specific compulsion urges such as the desire to check symptoms again, search online for answers, or call someone for reassurance, since naming these urges helps you resist performing them when they arise.

## DEPLOY THE INTERRUPT SEQUENCE

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- ❑ **Press your palms together firmly with moderate pressure for approximately 10 seconds when you notice your spiral beginning, because this resistance exercise activates proprioceptive receptors that signal safety to your hijacked nervous system.:** Press your palms together firmly with moderate pressure for approximately 10 seconds when you notice your spiral beginning, because this resistance exercise activates proprioceptive receptors that signal safety to your hijacked nervous system.
- ❑ **Name three specific visible objects out loud or in your head like 'the blue pen, the white light switch, the crack in the ceiling,' because identifying distinct items forces your prefrontal cortex to engage and interrupts the amygdala hijack driving your spiral.:** Name three specific visible objects out loud or in your head like 'the blue pen, the white light switch, the crack in the ceiling,' because identifying distinct items forces your prefrontal cortex to engage and interrupts the amygdala hijack driving your spiral.
- ❑ **Hold something cold against your skin for 15 seconds such as ice, a cold can, or cool water, because cold is one of the fastest physiological brakes available for stopping anxiety activation in its tracks.:** Hold something cold against your skin for 15 seconds such as ice, a cold can, or cool water, because cold is one of the fastest physiological brakes available for stopping anxiety activation in its tracks.
- ❑ **Speak the anchoring phrase 'This is the wait. The result has not arrived' out loud or silently as a factual anchor, because it grounds you in current reality rather than the catastrophic futures your OCD is manufacturing.:** Speak the anchoring phrase 'This is the wait. The result has not arrived' out loud or silently as a factual anchor, because it grounds you in current reality rather than the catastrophic futures your OCD is manufacturing.

## BUILD SUSTAINABLE COPING HABITS

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- ❑ **Move your body to a different physical location by standing up, walking to another room, or changing your posture, because movement actively breaks the freeze response that locks spirals in place and prevents further escalation.:** Move your body to a different physical location by standing up, walking to another room, or changing your posture, because movement actively breaks the freeze response that locks spirals in place and prevents further escalation.
- ❑ **Deploy the entire interrupt sequence within 60 to 90 seconds of noticing your spiral signature beginning, because the sooner you intervene, the less entrenched the cascade becomes and the easier it is to break.:** Deploy the entire interrupt sequence within 60 to 90 seconds of noticing your spiral signature beginning, because the sooner you intervene, the less entrenched the cascade becomes and the easier it is to break.

- **Resist performing safety behaviors like checking symptoms, searching online, or seeking reassurance, because these compulsions provide temporary relief but ultimately strengthen the anxiety loop you are trying to escape.:** Resist performing safety behaviors like checking symptoms, searching online, or seeking reassurance, because these compulsions provide temporary relief but ultimately strengthen the anxiety loop you are trying to escape.
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- **Prepare your grounding tools in advance by keeping a cold object nearby and writing your anchoring phrase somewhere visible, so you can access them quickly when spirals begin rather than scrambling during crisis moments.:**

Prepare your grounding tools in advance by keeping a cold object nearby and writing your anchoring phrase somewhere visible, so you can access them quickly when spirals begin rather than scrambling during crisis moments.

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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.